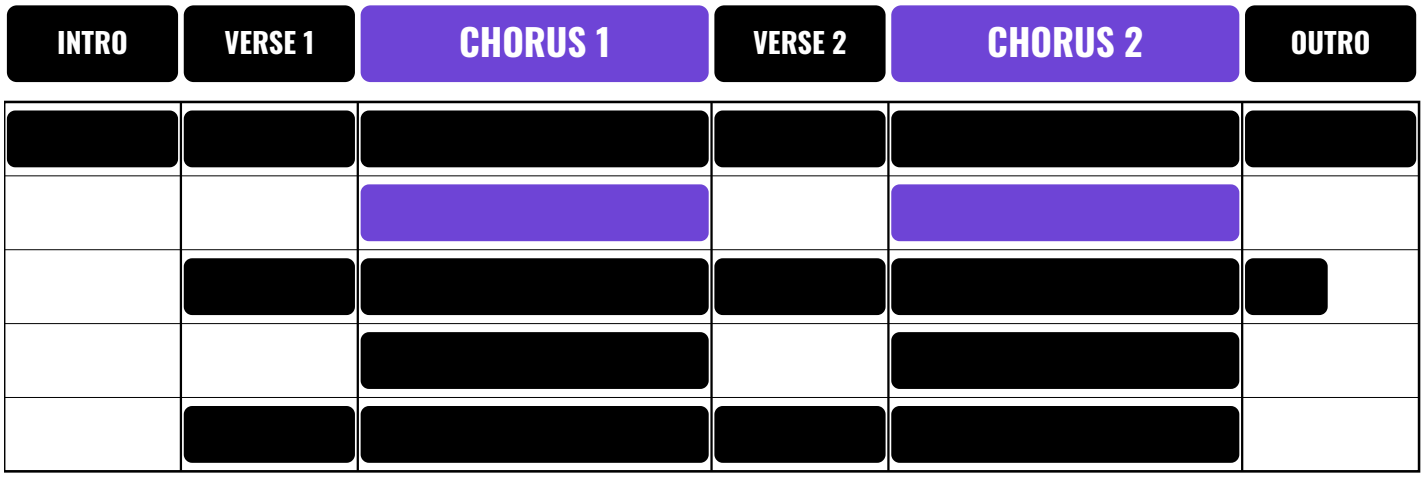
HUDSON BEAT




## SONG STRUCTURE IN LOGIC PRO

# SONG FORM

Digital Music Production 1 · Unit 5 · verse, chorus, bridge · arrangement · intro deck

GRADES 9–12 · 4 DAYS · 27 PAGES + 17-SLIDE DECK

# SONG FORM

How to use this resource

START HERE

Teacher

## WHAT THIS IS

A complete 4-day song structure unit for high school music technology. Day 1 is a listening day: students map the form of real pop songs on a Song Form sheet, two as a class and two on their own. Then they plan a form on paper and build it in Logic Pro: their own chords, bass and melody arranged into at least 4 sections (intro, verse and chorus required), with a chord layer and a drum transition at every section change. They present on Day 4.

This is Unit 5 of my Digital Music Production 1 course. It works on its own too, as long as students have a short chord progression and bassline to arrange (page 4).

## QUICK START

1. Read the overview and pacing (pages 3–6) and the teacher notes (pages 9–12).
2. Cue up the two class songs on YouTube or Spotify: Crazy (Gnarls Barkley) and Blinding Lights (The Weeknd). Check that students can play the four choice songs on headphones.
3. Check that every student has a Logic file with chords and a bassline (page 4).
4. Practice the 5-minute chord layer demo once (page 10).
5. Print or post the student pages (pages 13–24).

## THE INTRO DECK

Every slide has a day: Day 1 (slides 1–7), Day 2 (slides 8–16) and Day 4 (slide 17). The day plans name the slide for each block. Every slide has speaker notes.

Fonts: the deck uses Oswald and Source Sans 3 (free on Google Fonts, built into Google Slides). If PowerPoint or Keynote shows a different font, install the two fonts or present the PDF copy, which shows the intended look.

## WHAT'S INSIDE

| PART | PAGES | USE |
|---|---|---|
| **Teacher pages** | pages 2–12 | How to use, overview, setup, Logic reference, pacing, day plans, teacher notes |
| **Student pages** | pages 13–24 | Day 1 post, project sheet, planning table, Song Form sheets, compare page, vocabulary, checklist, rubric |
| **Answer key + example** | pages 25–26 | Form maps for all six songs, quick-check answers, a worked 32-measure skeleton |
| **Intro deck (separate file)** | deck | 17 slides, .pptx + PDF, speaker notes on every slide |

### ABOUT THE SONGS

Songs are named by title and artist only. Play them from your own YouTube or Spotify access; no audio, video or lyrics are included. The answer key lists only section names and measure counts.

## MAKE IT FIT YOUR CLASS

- **Less time?** Run it in 3 days as I first wrote it: fold Day 3 into Day 2's build time and finish on the last day with 20 minutes of work, then presentations (page 9).
- **More accessible / more advanced:** two variations on page 12.
- **Feedback board:** I use Padlet; any discussion board, LMS forum or paper gallery walk works.

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# SONG FORM

Unit overview



## WHAT STUDENTS MAKE

Four completed Song Form tables and a written response about the patterns they found. Then a structured arrangement in Logic of their own chords, bass and melody: at least 4 distinct sections (intro, verse and chorus required; bridge and outro encouraged), each at least 4 measures, labeled with arrangement markers, with a chord layer for texture and a drum transition at every section change. The worked example is a 32-measure skeleton (page 26).

## WHAT THIS UNIT IS REALLY ABOUT

This unit is a listening unit first and a building unit second. The Song Form sheet is not a worksheet to fill in: it is a tool for training students to hear structure the way a producer hears it. Students who genuinely engage with the analysis will arrive at the building phase already knowing what they want to do.

## MIXING CONCEPT: ARRANGEMENT AS MIX

Denser sections are fuller and louder; sparse sections have room and clarity. Every addition and removal of an element is audible and intentional. The chord layer demo makes it concrete: same notes, thicker texture, a bigger chorus.

## GOALS

- Identify and label sections in real songs using the Song Form sheet
- Understand what makes each section feel different from the others
- Recognize common structural patterns across different songs and genres
- Plan a song form before building it: intro, verse, chorus at minimum
- Build a structured arrangement of your chords, bass and melody in Logic with at least 4 distinct sections
- Use the presence and absence of elements to differentiate sections
- Signal every section change with a deliberate transition

## AT A GLANCE

| | |
|---|---|
| **Grades** | 9–12 (no music reading needed) |
| **Length** | 4 periods of about 53 minutes: listen and analyze, plan and build, differentiate, present |
| **Type** | Structured project: listening analysis, then arranging |
| **Software** | Logic Pro: arrangement markers, copy and repeat, a second instrument track, volume, export |
| **Product** | 4 song analyses + a written response; an arrangement with 4+ sections; MP3 + compressed project |
| **Assessment** | 5-category rubric, /25 (page 24) |

## STANDARDS

Supports the National Core Arts Standards for Music (Music Technology, high school): analyzing the structure of music (MU:Re7.2), organizing and developing musical ideas (MU:Cr2.1), refining work (MU:Cr3.1) and presenting it (MU:Pr6.1).

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# SONG FORM

Setup and requirements

**SETUP**

Teacher

## YOU NEED

- **A Mac with Logic Pro** and **headphones** for each student.
- **Each student's Logic file with a chord progression and a bassline.** In my course these come from the previous unit. Students add their melody on Day 2.
- **Projector and speakers** for the deck and the two class songs.
- **The six songs** from your own YouTube or Spotify access (table below); students play their two choices on headphones.
- **A place to submit** an MP3 and a .zip, and a **feedback board** for the three feedback questions.

## OPTIONAL

- A small MIDI keyboard (an MPK Mini or similar) for adding the melody.
- A Logic template with the arrangement markers already built (the "more accessible" variation, page 12).

## THE SONGS

| SONG | ARTIST | USE |
|---|---|---|
| **Crazy** | Gnarls Barkley | Class example, Day 1 |
| **Blinding Lights** | The Weeknd | Class example, Day 1 |
| **Anti-Hero** | Taylor Swift | Student choice (pick 2 of 4) |
| **good 4 u** | Olivia Rodrigo | Student choice (pick 2 of 4) |
| **Levitating** | Dua Lipa | Student choice (pick 2 of 4) |
| **Uptown Funk** | Bruno Mars | Student choice (pick 2 of 4) |

Songs are named by title and artist only. Play them from your own YouTube or Spotify access; no audio, video or lyrics are included.

### NO CHORDS-AND-BASSLINE FILE YET?

This unit arranges material students already have. If your students are new to Logic, give them one extra period (or homework) before Day 2 to make it:

- A 4-chord progression on a software instrument, one chord per measure. The worked example uses I–V–vi–IV in C major (C, G, Am, F).
- A bassline that plays the root of each chord.
- A simple drum beat (any kick, snare and hi-hat pattern).

The melody is added on Day 2 as part of the project.

## BEFORE DAY 1

- [ ] Cue up Crazy and Blinding Lights; test the projector sound. Know where the first two section changes are.
- [ ] Check that students can reach the four choice songs on headphones (or plan to play them for small groups).
- [ ] Check that every student can open a Logic file with chords and a bassline.
- [ ] Practice the chord layer demo once (page 10) and look at the worked skeleton (page 26).
- [ ] Print or post the student pages; set up the submission spot and the feedback board.
- [ ] Skim the answer key (page 25) so you can check measure counts quickly on Day 1.

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# SONG FORM

Logic quick reference

**SETUP**

Teacher

Everything students need in Logic for this unit, in one table. The planning table (page 16) comes before any of it.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Arrangement markers** | Show the global tracks (G), then the Arrangement track. Click + to add a marker; click its name to pick Intro, Verse, Chorus, Bridge or Outro, or rename it. Drag a marker's right edge to set the section length. |
| **Move or copy a section** | Drag an arrangement marker to move the whole section with its regions. Option-drag the marker to copy the section. |
| **Copy a region** | Option-drag a region to copy it, or select it and press Command-R to repeat it. |
| **New track** | Track › New Tracks (Option-Command-N), Software Instrument. |
| **Change the sound** | Open the Library (Y) and pick a patch for the selected track: a pad, an electric piano, a slow synth. |
| **Chord layer** | Option-drag a chord region onto a new track below, then change that track's instrument. Same notes, new texture. |
| **Take an element out** | Delete its region in that section (or never copy it in). To silence a whole track while you listen, click its M button. |
| **Loop a section** | Press C for Cycle and drag the cycle area over the section you are working on. |
| **Volume by section** | Track faders are in the Mixer (X). Show automation (A) and draw volume points to make a section louder or softer. |
| **Drum transitions** | Edit the last measure of a drum region (Piano Roll or Step Sequencer) for a fill, a build or a cut. With a Drummer track, raise the Fills knob for that region. |
| **Export** | File › Bounce › Project or Section (Command-B), MP3. In Finder, Control-click the .logicx project and choose Compress. |

### MEASURE MATH

Sections are almost always 4 or 8 measures. The worked skeleton: 4 + 4 + 8 + 4 + 8 + 4 = 32 measures. At 4 beats per measure that is 128 beats: about a minute at 120–128 BPM.

### VERSION NOTE

Menu names are from current Logic Pro versions; older versions may differ slightly. Logic Pro and Drummer are trademarks of Apple Inc., named only to describe what the unit needs. This resource is not affiliated with Apple.

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# SONG FORM

Pacing guide · 4 days

**PACING**

Teacher

Four class periods of about 53 minutes: a listening day, a planning and building day, a day to differentiate the sections, then finishing and presenting. Each day's full plan is on pages 7–8.

| DAY | FOCUS AND GOAL | MINUTE BLOCKS | DECK |
|---|---|---|---|
| **DAY 1**<br>Learning | **Song form analysis: a listening day**<br>All four Song Form sheets complete. Written response answered. Students have the vocabulary and structural intuition to plan their own form. | 0–12 · Hook + class example 1<br>12–25 · Class example 2<br>25–45 · Independent analysis<br>45–53 · Share-out | Intro deck slides 1–7 |
| **DAY 2**<br>Work day | **Plan + build the skeleton**<br>Planning table complete, melody added, arrangement skeleton built with a marker on every section. | 0–5 · Chord layer demo<br>5–12 · The project<br>12–25 · Plan + melody<br>25–50 · Build the skeleton<br>50–53 · Save + note | Intro deck slides 8–16 |
| **DAY 3**<br>Work day | **Differentiate the sections**<br>Chord layer added, melody placed on purpose, a drum transition at every section change; verse and chorus clearly different. | 0–5 · The mute test<br>5–45 · Differentiate<br>45–53 · Play-through | No slides |
| **DAY 4**<br>Finish + present | **Finish, submit, present**<br>Every project submitted and presented; every student can point to the chorus and say why it feels bigger. | 0–20 · Finish + submit<br>20–50 · Presentations<br>50–53 · Close | Intro deck slide 17 |

## STUDENT PAGES BY DAY ·

| | |
|---|---|
| **Day 1** | Day 1 post (p. 13), Song Form sheets (pp. 18–20), Compare the forms and written response (p. 21) |
| **Day 2** | Project sheet (pp. 14–15), planning table (p. 16), steps (p. 17) |
| **Day 3** | Steps 4–5 (p. 17), vocabulary (p. 22) |
| **Day 4** | Submission checklist (p. 23), rubric for self-score and teacher score (p. 24) |

### THREE DAYS INSTEAD OF FOUR

My Teacher Notes run this unit in 3 days: Day 1 as here; Day 2 plans and builds, adds the chord layer and starts the transitions; Day 3 gives 20 minutes to finish and submit, then presentations. The four-day plan keeps the same blocks and gives building its own day.

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# SONG FORM

Day-by-day plans · Days 1 and 2

**DAYS 1–2**

Listen + plan

## DAY 1 · SONG FORM ANALYSIS: A LISTENING DAY

Learning · Intro deck slides 1–7

**Goal:** All four Song Form sheets complete. Written response answered. Students have the vocabulary and structural intuition to plan their own form.

**0–12** **HOOK + CLASS EXAMPLE 1** [slides 1–3] · Slides 1–2 (two minutes): every song has a blueprint, and what song form means. Then slide 3: Crazy by Gnarls Barkley, first 2–3 minutes only. Three listens: feel the change, label the sections, count the measures. Key question: why does the chorus feel bigger?

**12–25** **CLASS EXAMPLE 2** [slides 4–5] · Slide 4 (one minute): what each section does. Slide 5: Blinding Lights by The Weeknd. Students lead more of the labeling. Faster pace. Compare to example 1: same structure? Different? What is the same across both?

**25–45** **INDEPENDENT ANALYSIS** [slide 6] · Slide 6. Students independently analyze two songs from the list on the Song Form sheet (pages 18–20). Circulate and check that sections are labeled and measures counted.

**45–53** **SHARE-OUT** [slide 7] · Slide 7. What patterns showed up in every song? Surface the two key observations: sections are almost always 4 or 8 bars, chorus is always texturally fuller than verse. Students write the response (page 21).

## DAY 2 · PLAN + BUILD THE SKELETON

Work day · Intro deck slides 8–16

**Goal:** Planning table complete, melody added, arrangement skeleton built with a marker on every section.

**0–5** **CHORD LAYER DEMO** [slides 8–9] · Slide 8: arrangement is what plays where. Then demo the chord layer technique live in Logic (slide 9; 5 minutes only, steps on page 10).

**5–12** **THE PROJECT** [slides 10–16] · Slides 10–16: the worked 32-measure skeleton, plan before you build, the four transitions, the project, the steps, what to turn in and the rubric.

**12–25** **PLAN + MELODY** · Students complete the planning table (page 16) and add their melody to their chords-and-bassline Logic file. No Logic arrangement work until the plan is done: check each student.

**25–50** **BUILD THE SKELETON** · Students add arrangement markers and copy their elements into the sections. Skeleton first: the correct elements in the right places, before refining anything.

**50–53** **SAVE + NOTE** · Students save and write down what is left: chord layer, transitions, mix.

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# SONG FORM

Day-by-day plans · Days 3 and 4

**DAYS 3–4**

Build + present

## DAY 3 · DIFFERENTIATE THE SECTIONS

Work day · No slides

**Goal:** Chord layer added, melody placed on purpose, a drum transition at every section change; verse and chorus clearly different.

**0–5** **THE MUTE TEST** · Mini-lesson: mute the melody track. Does the chorus still feel bigger? If not, the arrangement is not doing any work yet.

**5–45** **DIFFERENTIATE** · Students add the chord layer, place the melody only where it belongs, and add a drum transition at every section change (fill, breakdown, cut or build). Circulate with the prompts below.

**45–53** **PLAY-THROUGH** · Each student plays the arrangement start to finish: can you hear which section you are in without looking at the screen? Note one fix for Day 4. Students who are close to done export and submit.

## DAY 4 · FINISH, SUBMIT, PRESENT

Finish + present · Intro deck slide 17

**Goal:** Every project submitted and presented; every student can point to the chorus and say why it feels bigger.

**0–20** **FINISH + SUBMIT** · Students finalize transitions, mix volumes, export, and submit. Three feedback questions go on the class feedback board.

**20–50** **PRESENTATIONS** · Each student plays their full arrangement. Ask: point to your chorus. Why does it feel different from your verse? What did you do to make that happen?

**50–53** **CLOSE** [slide 17] · Slide 17. ‘What you just heard (intro, verse, chorus, verse, chorus) is the structure of almost every pop song ever released. You did not just copy that structure. You understood it well enough to build it yourself.’

### CIRCULATING PROMPTS (DAY 3)

- ‘Play me your verse, then your chorus. What is in the chorus that is not in the verse?’
- ‘Mute your melody. Does the chorus still feel bigger?’
- ‘Which transition type is this: fill, breakdown, cut or build? Why that one here?’

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## WHAT THIS UNIT IS REALLY ABOUT ·

This unit is a listening unit first and a building unit second. The Song Form sheet is not a worksheet to fill in: it is a tool for training students to hear structure the way a producer hears it. Students who genuinely engage with the analysis will arrive at the building phase already knowing what they want to do. Students who rush through it will spend Day 2 guessing.

The central insight you are trying to land: sections feel different because of what is playing, not just because of a label. A chorus is not called a chorus because someone decided to call it that. It is called a chorus because it is texturally fuller, emotionally bigger, and more memorable than the verse. That is a compositional decision, not a naming decision.

## DAY 1: HOW TO RUN THE CLASS ANALYSIS ·

The two class examples should be tight: 10 to 12 minutes each. Play the first 2–3 minutes of each song only, enough to get through at least two verse-chorus cycles. Here is how to structure each one:

- **First listen (90 seconds):** Play without stopping. Ask students to raise their hand when they feel the section change. Do not define: just listen.
- **Second listen:** Pause at each section change. Ask: what changed? What came in or dropped out? Students call it out. You label it on the board.
- **Measure count:** Play one more time and count together out loud. Students will usually discover on their own that sections land in multiples of 4.
- **Key question before moving on:** Why does the chorus feel bigger? What specifically is different? Push for musical answers, not just 'it sounds louder'.

The share-out at the end of Day 1 is important. Ask: what patterns did you notice across all four songs? Students should arrive at: sections are almost always 4 or 8 bars, chorus is always fuller than verse, intros build in and outros strip back. These are the principles they will apply the next day.

### HOW THIS KIT DIFFERS FROM MY CLASSROOM VERSION

- My Teacher Notes pace the unit in 3 days; this kit uses the 4 days of my course plan and gives building its own day (page 6).
- Students arrange chords and a bassline they made earlier; if they have none, see page 4. The worked 32-measure skeleton (page 26) is new.
- The Song Form spreadsheet is printed as tables, with the written response and an optional comparison grid on one page (page 21). My LMS and Padlet are written as "your class page" and "the class feedback board".

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## SUGGESTED SONGS ·

| SONG | ARTIST | USE | WHY IT WORKS |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Crazy** | Gnarls Barkley | *Class example* | Very simple form. |
| **Blinding Lights** | The Weeknd | *Class example* | Verse is sparse and unsettled. Chorus erupts with full synth pad and drums. Section change is physically felt. Textbook structure. |
| **Anti-Hero** | Taylor Swift | *Independent option* | Clear verse/pre-chorus/chorus/bridge. Good for introducing what a pre-chorus does: builds tension before the drop. |
| **good 4 u** | Olivia Rodrigo | *Independent option* | Strong bridge that genuinely contrasts with the verse-chorus cycle. Good for finding a bridge in the wild. |
| **Levitating** | Dua Lipa | *Independent option* | Clean pop structure with a pre-chorus students will not have consciously noticed before. Good for more advanced students. |
| **Uptown Funk** | Bruno Mars | *Independent option* | Near-universal recognition. Has a clear break section. Good for showing not all songs follow the same template. |

Songs are named by title and artist only. Play them from your own YouTube or Spotify access; no audio, video or lyrics are included.

## DAY 2: ENFORCE THE PLANNING TABLE ·

Do not let any student open the arrangement view until their planning table is filled in. Walk around at the start of the work time and check each one. What to look for:

- The chorus has more elements than the verse
- The intro starts with fewer elements than the verse
- Every section change has a transition type written down
- Sections are labeled with real names, not just ‘Part 1’ and ‘Part 2’

If a student has the same elements in every section, send them back to the sheet: look at the song you analyzed. What dropped out in the verse? That is what you need to do here.

## THE CHORD LAYER DEMO (5 MINUTES, START OF DAY 2) ·

1. Option-drag a chord region to duplicate it onto a new track below
2. Change the instrument to something with a different character: a pad, a Rhodes, a slow-attack synth
3. Play both chord tracks together: the texture thickens without the notes changing
4. Mute the second track in the verse, unmute it in the chorus
5. Play the full arrangement and ask: can you hear the chorus get bigger? That is arrangement as mix.

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## CALLBACKS TO EARLIER UNITS ·

If your students did these projects (all part of my DMP1 course), name them out loud.

**Drum beats (Beat From Nothing):** Drum beats return here to anchor sections. Remind students: a drum pattern that does not change across section changes sounds like a loop, not a song.

**Transitions (Stems & Grooves):** The four transition types (fill, breakdown, cut, build) are the vocabulary for every section change in this unit. Ask students to name which type they used and why.

**Chords, bass and melody (Building Blocks):** These are the raw materials. This unit is purely about where those materials go and what they do in each section.

## COMMON STUDENT STRUGGLES ·

**All sections sound the same:** The most common failure. The test: mute the melody track. Does the chorus still feel bigger? If not, the arrangement is not doing any work. Ask the student to listen to their analyzed song again and compare.

**Rushing through the spreadsheet:** Students who treat the analysis as a checkbox exercise will not have the vocabulary or intuition to plan their own form. Enforce quality: every section labeled, every measure counted, the written response answered thoughtfully.

**Intros at full energy:** Students start with everything playing because they are not thinking about the listener. Ask: if someone walked into the room mid-sentence, would they know what was coming? The intro should earn attention, not assume it.

**No transitions:** Students paste their drum groove everywhere and call it done. The transition is what tells the listener something changed. A section change with no acknowledgment sounds like a loop.

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## SUGGESTED VARIATIONS ·

**More accessible:** Pre-build the arrangement markers in the Logic file and ask students to drag elements in rather than build from scratch. Reduce the minimum to 3 sections: intro, verse, chorus.

**More advanced:** Require a bridge that uses a chord not in the main progression (specifically the vi or iv) held for 8 bars before the final chorus. Require all four transition types to appear at least once.

## GRADING TIPS ·

- Each category is scored 2–5, for a total out of 25. Students self-score first; you score in the second column (page 24).
- Song Form Analysis: check the measure counts against the answer key (page 25). Small differences (a pickup counted, a section split in two) are fine when the student clearly counted.
- Listen once eyes-closed for Section Differentiation: can you name each section by ear? Then open the project to check the markers, section lengths and the chord layer track.
- The presentation question is the quickest evidence of intention: point to your chorus; why does it feel different from your verse?

## RESOURCES ·

- The intro deck (.pptx and PDF), included.
- The six songs, from your own YouTube or Spotify access (page 4).
- The worked skeleton (page 26) to model on Day 2 or to play from while you circulate.

## OBSERVATION NOTES ·

What worked, what to adjust, and anything worth remembering for next year.

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# SONG FORM · DAY 1

Digital Music Production 1 · Unit 5

Today is a listening day. You are not building anything in Logic. You are training your ear to hear how songs are put together.

**All four Song Form tables must be complete before you leave today.**

1. **LISTEN AS A CLASS: SONG 1** · Your teacher will play Crazy by Gnarls Barkley. Listen first without doing anything. Raise your hand when you feel the section change.
   *Do not try to name it yet. Just notice when the energy or texture shifts.*

2. **LABEL SONG 1 TOGETHER** · Play it again and label every section as a class. Count the measures. What elements are playing in each section? What drops out? What comes in?
   *Key question: why does the chorus feel bigger than the verse? What specifically is different?*

3. **LISTEN AS A CLASS: SONG 2** · Your teacher will play Blinding Lights by The Weeknd. Same process, but this time you are leading more of the labeling.
   *Compare to song 1: same structure? What is the same across both songs?*

4. **INDEPENDENT ANALYSIS: YOUR TWO SONGS** · Turn to the Song Form sheets (pages 19–20). Choose two songs from the list and complete a table for each. Label every section, count the measures, note what elements are playing.
   *The more carefully you do this, the easier Day 2 will be. These observations become your blueprint.*

5. **WRITTEN RESPONSE** · On the Compare the Forms page (page 21), write two or three sentences: what patterns did you notice across all four songs? What showed up every time?
   *There is no single right answer, but there are patterns. Look for them.*

### CHOOSE TWO OF THESE FOR YOUR INDEPENDENT ANALYSIS

**Anti-Hero · Taylor Swift** *Clear verse / pre-chorus / chorus / bridge structure*

**good 4 u · Olivia Rodrigo** *Strong bridge that genuinely contrasts with the verse-chorus cycle*

**Levitating · Dua Lipa** *Clean pop form with a pre-chorus you may not have consciously noticed before*

**Uptown Funk · Bruno Mars** *Classic structure with a break section that functions differently from a bridge*

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# PROJECT SHEET

Digital Music Production 1 · Unit 5 · Structured · 4 Days · Arrangement as Mix

## OVERVIEW ·

Every song you have ever heard is built on a structure. Verses, choruses, bridges, intros, outros: these sections are not accidents. They are deliberate decisions about energy, tension, and release. In this unit you will train your ear to hear those decisions in real songs, then make your own. You will build a structured arrangement of your chords, bass and melody with clearly differentiated sections: ones that feel different from each other because of what is playing, not just because a label says so.

## GOALS ·

- Identify and label sections in real songs using the Song Form sheet
- Understand what makes each section feel different from the others
- Recognize common structural patterns across different songs and genres
- Plan a song form before building it: intro, verse, chorus at minimum
- Build a structured arrangement of your chords, bass and melody in Logic with at least 4 distinct sections
- Use the presence and absence of elements to differentiate sections
- Signal every section change with a deliberate transition

## WHAT EACH SECTION DOES ·

A section is not just a label. It has a job. Understanding the job tells you how to build it.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Intro** | Earns the listener's attention. Usually starts with one or two elements and builds. Does not need to be complicated: just needs to feel like a beginning. |
| **Verse** | Gives the listener space to settle in. Sparser than the chorus. If the chorus is the payoff, the verse is the setup. A weak verse makes a chorus feel less powerful. |
| **Pre-Chorus** | Optional but effective. Builds tension in the last 2–4 measures before the chorus drops. Often raises energy slightly so the chorus feels like a release. |
| **Chorus** | The emotional peak. Should feel fuller, louder, and more energetic than the verse. This is where the melody is most prominent. Copy and paste: it is the same every time it returns. |
| **Bridge** | Breaks the pattern. Usually appears once, after the second chorus. Different chord, different energy, or stripped back completely. Makes the final chorus feel earned. |
| **Outro** | Brings it home. Often mirrors the intro, stripping elements back one by one. Ends cleanly. Does not just fade out in the middle of a loop. |

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# SONG FORM

Project sheet · requirements and tips

**STUDENT**



## REQUIREMENTS ·

- [ ] Song Form sheet completed for all four songs: two as a class, two independently
- [ ] Written response: what did you notice across all four songs? (see the Day 1 question)
- [ ] Melody added to your chords-and-bassline Logic file so all three elements are in one place
- [ ] Song form planned on paper before building: at least 4 sections with labels and lengths
- [ ] Arrangement built in Logic with arrangement markers labeling every section
- [ ] At least 4 distinct sections: intro, verse, chorus required; bridge and outro encouraged
- [ ] Each section at least 4 measures long
- [ ] Verse and chorus must feel clearly different from each other
- [ ] At least one chord layer added on a second instrument for texture contrast
- [ ] Drum track with a transition at every section change
- [ ] Project named: Your Name – Song Form
- [ ] Exported as MP3 and .zip (compressed .logicx file) and submitted before presenting

## TIPS FOR SUCCESS ·

- The chorus should feel bigger than the verse. If they sound the same, something is missing. Add the melody, layer the chords on a second instrument, or thicken the drums.
- Sections are almost always 4 or 8 bars long. If you analyzed the four songs carefully, you already know this from experience.
- Copy and paste is not lazy. Every professional arranger does it. Write once, arrange many times.
- Your intro does not need to be complicated. One element playing alone for 4 bars is a stronger intro than everything at full volume from bar one.
- Every section change needs a transition. If you can hear where one section ends and another begins without looking at the screen, your transitions are working.

**THE TEST**

Play it from start to finish. Can you hear which section you are in without looking at the screen?

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# SONG FORM

Project sheet · plan your song form

**STUDENT**



Name _____ Date _____

**Fill this in before you open Logic.** Every section needs a job, a length, and a plan for what is playing.

**MY KEY**

- ☐ C major
- ☐ A minor
- ☐ **Other:** _____

**CHORD PROGRESSION (ROMAN NUMERALS)**

[ ] – [ ] – [ ] – [ ]

| SECTION | BARS | ELEMENTS PLAYING<br>chords / bass / melody / drums / chord layer | TRANSITION INTO NEXT SECTION |
|---|---|---|---|
| **INTRO** | | | |
| **VERSE 1** | | | |
| **CHORUS 1** | | | |
| **VERSE 2** | | | |
| **CHORUS 2** | | | |
| **BRIDGE (OPTIONAL)** | | | |
| **OUTRO** | | | |

Each section at least 4 measures. Transitions: fill, breakdown, cut or build. Worked example: page 26.

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# SONG FORM

Project sheet · steps

**STUDENT**



Name _____ Date _____

## STEPS / PROCESS ·

**1** **DAY 1 · ANALYZE REAL SONGS**

Complete the Song Form sheet for all four songs. Two as a class, two independently. For each song: label every section, count the measures, and note what elements are playing. Ask yourself after each one: why does the chorus feel the way it does?

**2** **DAY 2 · ADD YOUR MELODY**

Open your chords-and-bassline Logic file. Add your melody so all three elements (chords, bass, and melody) are in one place. Call your teacher over to check before moving on.

**3** **DAY 2 · PLAN BEFORE YOU BUILD**

Fill in the planning table on this sheet. Every section needs a name, a length, a list of what is playing, and a transition. Do this on paper. Do not open the arrangement view until your plan is complete.

**4** **DAYS 2–3 · BUILD YOUR STRUCTURE**

Add arrangement markers in Logic for every section in your plan. Copy your existing elements into the correct sections. Build the skeleton first (correct elements in the right places) before refining anything.

**5** **DAY 3 · DIFFERENTIATE YOUR SECTIONS**

Go back through and make sure the chorus feels different from the verse. Add a chord layer on a second instrument for the chorus. Add the melody only where it belongs. Make sure every section change has a drum transition.

**6** **DAY 4 · MIX AND SUBMIT**

Play the full arrangement from start to finish. Can you hear which section you are in without looking at the screen? If yes, your arrangement is working. Adjust volumes, export, and submit.

## NOTES ·

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# SONG FORM

Song Form in pop music



Name _____ Date _____

Songs 1 and 2: we do these together. Listen, raise your hand at each section change, then label the sections and count the measures as a class.

## SONG 1 · CRAZY

Gnarls Barkley AS A CLASS

| # | SECTION | MEASURES | WHAT'S PLAYING · WHAT CHANGED |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | *Intro* | | |
| 2 | *Verse* | | |
| 3 | *Chorus* | | |
| 4 | *Verse* | | |
| 5 | *Chorus* | | |
| 6 | *Verse* | | |
| 7 | *Chorus* | | |
| 8 | *Outro* | | |
| 9 | | | |
| 10 | | | |
| 11 | | | |
| 12 | | | |
| 13 | | | |
| 14 | | | |
| 15 | | | |

## SONG 2 · BLINDING LIGHTS

The Weeknd AS A CLASS

| # | SECTION | MEASURES | WHAT'S PLAYING · WHAT CHANGED |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | *Intro (Pop Drop)* | | |
| 2 | *Verse* | | |
| 3 | *Pre-chorus* | | |
| 4 | *Chorus* | | |
| 5 | *Pop Drop* | | |
| 6 | | | |
| 7 | | | |
| 8 | | | |
| 9 | | | |
| 10 | | | |
| 11 | | | |
| 12 | | | |
| 13 | | | |
| 14 | | | |
| 15 | | | |

Grey labels were filled in for you. For each section: name it, count the measures, and write what is playing or what changed (what came in, what dropped out).

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# SONG FORM

Song Form in pop music



Name _____ Date _____

Songs 3–6: choose two of these four and complete a table for each. Play them on headphones from YouTube or Spotify.

## SONG 3 · ANTI-HERO

Taylor Swift (MY CHOICE?)

| # | SECTION | MEASURES | WHAT'S PLAYING · WHAT CHANGED |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | *Intro* | | |
| 2 | *Verse* | | |
| 3 | *Chorus* | | |
| 4 | *Post chorus* | | |
| 5 | | | |
| 6 | | | |
| 7 | | | |
| 8 | | | |
| 9 | | | |
| 10 | | | |
| 11 | | | |
| 12 | | | |
| 13 | | | |
| 14 | | | |
| 15 | | | |

## SONG 4 · GOOD 4 U

Olivia Rodrigo (MY CHOICE?)

| # | SECTION | MEASURES | WHAT'S PLAYING · WHAT CHANGED |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | *Intro* | | |
| 2 | *Verse* | | |
| 3 | *Chorus* | | |
| 4 | *Post chorus* | | |
| 5 | | | |
| 6 | | | |
| 7 | | | |
| 8 | | | |
| 9 | | | |
| 10 | | | |
| 11 | | | |
| 12 | | | |
| 13 | | | |
| 14 | | | |
| 15 | | | |

Grey labels were filled in for you. For each section: name it, count the measures, and write what is playing or what changed (what came in, what dropped out).

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# SONG FORM

Song Form in pop music



Name _____ Date _____

Choose two of songs 3–6 in total. No labels are filled in on these two: you name every section yourself.

## SONG 5 · LEVITATING

Dua Lipa (MY CHOICE?)

| # | SECTION | MEASURES | WHAT'S PLAYING · WHAT CHANGED |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | | |
| 2 | | | |
| 3 | | | |
| 4 | | | |
| 5 | | | |
| 6 | | | |
| 7 | | | |
| 8 | | | |
| 9 | | | |
| 10 | | | |
| 11 | | | |
| 12 | | | |
| 13 | | | |
| 14 | | | |
| 15 | | | |

## SONG 6 · UPTOWN FUNK

Bruno Mars (MY CHOICE?)

| # | SECTION | MEASURES | WHAT'S PLAYING · WHAT CHANGED |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | | |
| 2 | | | |
| 3 | | | |
| 4 | | | |
| 5 | | | |
| 6 | | | |
| 7 | | | |
| 8 | | | |
| 9 | | | |
| 10 | | | |
| 11 | | | |
| 12 | | | |
| 13 | | | |
| 14 | | | |
| 15 | | | |

Grey labels were filled in for you. For each section: name it, count the measures, and write what is playing or what changed (what came in, what dropped out).

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# SONG FORM

Compare the forms · written response



Name _____ Date _____

Line your four songs up side by side. The grid is optional: use it to find the patterns, then write your response.

| SONG | HOW MANY SECTIONS? | MOST COMMON LENGTH | PRE-CHORUS? | BRIDGE? | WHAT MAKES THE CHORUS BIGGER? |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **1 · Crazy** | | | | | |
| **2 · Blinding Lights** | | | | | |
| **3 · _____** | | | | | |
| **4 · _____** | | | | | |
| **My song (after Day 3)** | | | | | |

## WRITTEN RESPONSE ·

What patterns did you notice across all four songs? What showed up every time? Write two or three sentences.

*There is no single right answer, but there are patterns. Look for them.*

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# SONG FORM

Key vocabulary

**STUDENT**

10 words

Name _____ Date _____

Read each word and its meaning. In the last column, write where it shows up in your own song.

| WORD | MEANING | IN MY SONG |
|---|---|---|
| **Song form** | the overall structure of a song: how its sections are organized from beginning to end | |
| **Intro** | opens the song: establishes the sound and draws the listener in before the verse begins. Usually sparse. | |
| **Verse** | tells the story. Sparser than the chorus. Repeats with varied content. Sets up the emotional release of the chorus. | |
| **Pre-chorus** | a short section between verse and chorus that builds tension before the drop. Not all songs have one. | |
| **Chorus** | the emotional peak. Fuller, louder, the most memorable part. Usually returns multiple times unchanged. | |
| **Bridge** | a contrasting section that breaks the verse-chorus cycle. Creates tension or surprise before the final chorus. | |
| **Outro** | brings the song to a close. Often strips elements back one by one. Mirrors the intro in energy. | |
| **Texture** | how thick or thin the sound is: determined by how many elements are playing at once | |
| **Arrangement** | the decisions about which elements play in which sections: what comes in, what drops out, and when | |
| **Transition** | the moment between sections that signals a change: drum fill, breakdown, cut, or build | |

## QUICK CHECK · ANSWERS ON PAGE 25

**1. The _____ is the emotional peak of a song: fuller, louder, the most memorable part.** _____

**2. How thick or thin the sound is (how many elements play at once) is its _____.** _____

**3. A drum fill, breakdown, cut or build between sections is a _____.** _____

**4. The decisions about which elements play in which sections are the _____.** _____

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# SONG FORM

Submission checklist

**STUDENT**

Before you present

Name _____ Date _____

Tick each box before you submit and present. If a box isn't ticked, you aren't done yet.

- [ ] Song Form sheet completed for all four songs
- [ ] Written response to the pattern question completed
- [ ] Melody added to my chords-and-bassline Logic file
- [ ] Song form planning table filled in before building
- [ ] At least 4 distinct sections with arrangement markers
- [ ] Each section at least 4 measures long
- [ ] Verse and chorus clearly different from each other
- [ ] Chord layer added on a second instrument for texture contrast
- [ ] Drum track with a transition at every section change
- [ ] Project named: Your Name – Song Form
- [ ] Exported as MP3 and .zip (compressed .logicx file) and submitted before presenting
- [ ] Three feedback questions posted to the class feedback board before presenting

## MY THREE FEEDBACK QUESTIONS ·

Ask about something you really want to know. Example: "Can you tell when my chorus starts without looking?"

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

## NOTES ·

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# SONG FORM

Rubric

**RUBRIC**

/ 25

Name _____ Date _____

Score each category from 2 to 5. Score yourself first, then your teacher scores.

| Category | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | Self | Teacher |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **SONG FORM ANALYSIS** | Fewer than two spreadsheets completed. Sections not labeled or measures not counted. Written response missing. | All four spreadsheets complete but with labeling errors or missing measure counts. Written response is vague. | All four spreadsheets complete and mostly accurate. Written response identifies at least one pattern across songs. | All four spreadsheets complete and accurate. Written response shows genuine insight about how song structure works across different songs. | | |
| **SONG FORM STRUCTURE** | Fewer than 3 sections built. No arrangement markers. No clear structural plan evident. | At least 3 sections but some are unlabeled or too short. Planning table not completed before building. | At least 4 labeled sections, each at least 4 measures. Planning table completed. Intro, verse, and chorus all present. | Form is well-constructed and clearly planned. All required sections present. Structure feels like a complete song with a beginning, middle, and end. | | |
| **SECTION DIFFERENTIATION** | All sections sound the same. No meaningful difference in texture or elements between sections. | Some difference between sections but verse and chorus are not clearly distinct. Layering absent or ineffective. | Verse and chorus clearly different. At least one chord layer added on a second instrument. Melody placement is intentional. | Multiple sections have distinct textures. Addition and removal of elements is deliberate. Listener can identify the section by ear without looking at the screen. | | |
| **ARRANGEMENT AS MIX** | No evidence of mix decisions tied to arrangement. All elements at equal volume throughout with no change between sections. | Some volume awareness but mix does not meaningfully reflect arrangement. Dense and sparse sections feel similar in the mix. | Mix reflects the arrangement plan. Denser sections are fuller and louder. Sparse sections have room and clarity. | Arrangement and mix work as one. Every addition and removal of an element is audible and intentional. Nothing is clipping. | | |
| **DOCUMENTATION & PRESENTATION** | Project not submitted or not presented. | Project submitted late or named incorrectly. Minimal presentation engagement. | Project named correctly and submitted. Presentation made. Feedback questions posted. | Project correctly named, on time. Student explains form and arrangement choices clearly, referencing specific sections. Three thoughtful feedback questions posted. | | |
| | | | | **TOTAL** | **/ 25** | **/ 25** |

## MY CHORUS IS BIGGER BECAUSE...

_____

_____

## TEACHER COMMENTS

_____

_____

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# SONG FORM

Answer key · form maps

**ANSWER KEY**

Teacher

Section names and measure counts from my classroom analysis (bars to scale; **violet** = chorus, black = intro, verse, bridge and outro, grey = other sections). Accept small differences when a student clearly counted, for example a pickup measure or a section split in two. The label “Bridge/Chorus?” is my own: that section works either way, so accept both. The teacher notes suggest Anti-Hero for introducing the pre-chorus, but my analysis does not list one separately; accept a pre-chorus if a student splits one out of the end of a verse.

**Bar codes: IN** intro · **V** verse · **PRE** pre-chorus · **CH** chorus · **POST** post chorus · **DROP** pop drop · **BR** bridge · **BR A** bridge A · **BR B** bridge B · **BR/CH** bridge/chorus? · **OUT** outro. A code above the map with a short line belongs to the narrow bar the line points to.

## 1 · CRAZY · Gnarls Barkley

8 sections




Intro **1** · Verse **16** · Chorus **8** · Verse **16** · Chorus **8** · Verse **16** · Chorus **8** · Outro **8**

## 2 · BLINDING LIGHTS · The Weeknd

12 sections




Intro (Pop Drop) **12 (4+8)** · Verse **16** · Pre-chorus **8** · Chorus **16** · Pop Drop **8** · Verse **8** · Pre-chorus **8** · Chorus **16** · Bridge **8** · Chorus **8** · Pop Drop (2x) **16** · Outro **8**

## 3 · ANTI-HERO · Taylor Swift

11 sections




Intro **2** · Verse **16** · Chorus **8** · Post chorus **2** · Verse **16** · Chorus **8** · Post chorus **2** · Verse **8** · Bridge/Chorus? **8** · Chorus **8** · Outro **2**

## 4 · GOOD 4 U · Olivia Rodrigo

11 sections




Intro **4** · Verse **16** · Chorus **16** · Post chorus **4** · Verse **16** · Chorus **16** · Post chorus **4** · Bridge A **8** · Bridge B **16** · Chorus **16** · Outro **6**

## 5 · LEVITATING · Dua Lipa

12 sections




Intro **4** · Verse **8** · Pre-chorus **4** · Chorus **8** · Post chorus **2** · Verse **8** · Pre-chorus **4** · Chorus **8** · Bridge A **8** · Bridge B **8** · Pre-chorus **4** · Chorus (2x) **16**

## 6 · UPTOWN FUNK · Bruno Mars

15 sections




Intro **8** · Verse **8** · Pre-chorus **8** · Chorus **8** · Pop Drop (Horns) **8** · Post Chorus **4** · Verse **8** · Pre-chorus **8** · Chorus **8** · Pop Drop (Horns) **8** · Post Chorus **4** · Bridge **20** · Pop Drop (Horns) **8** · Post Chorus **4** · Outro **16**

### VOCABULARY · QUICK CHECK

**1.** chorus · **2.** texture · **3.** transition · **4.** arrangement

### SHARE-OUT PATTERNS

Sections are almost always 4 or 8 bars; The chorus is always (texturally) fuller than the verse; Intros build in and outros strip back.

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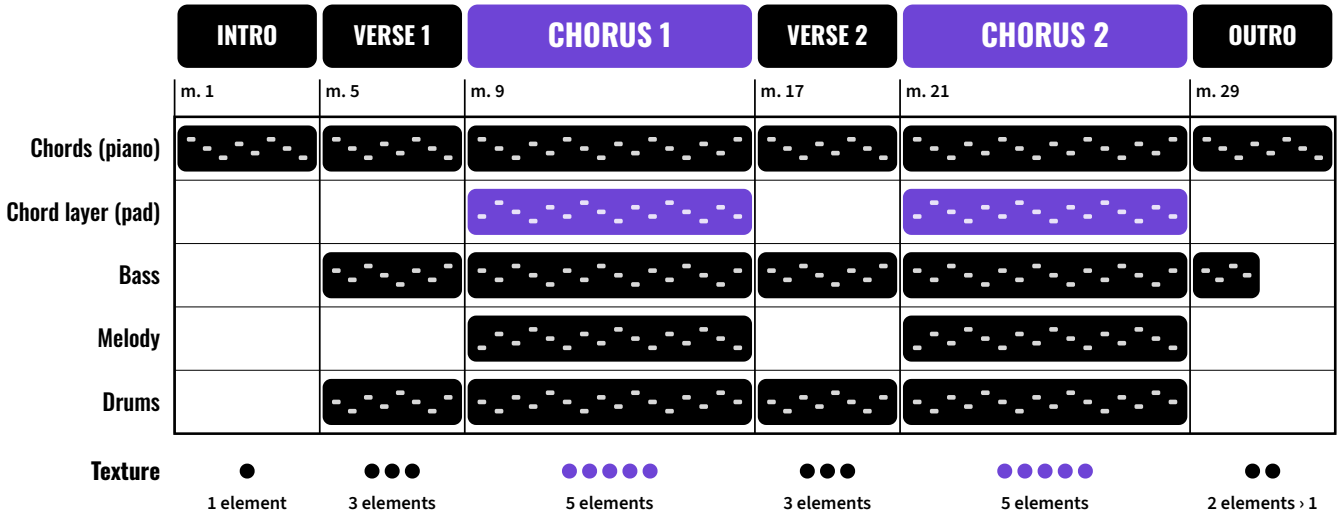
# SONG FORM

EXAMPLE

Example notes · a worked 32-measure skeleton

Teacher

A 32-measure skeleton to model on Day 2 or to play from while you circulate: chords I–V–vi–IV in C major (C G Am F), one chord per measure. It is one possible answer, not the answer.




| SECTION | BARS | ELEMENTS PLAYING<br>chords / bass / melody / drums / chord layer | TRANSITION INTO NEXT SECTION |
|---|---|---|---|
| **INTRO** | 4 | chords | **Fill:** a one-measure drum fill in m. 4 brings the drums in |
| **VERSE 1** | 4 | chords, bass, drums | **Build:** snare on every eighth note in m. 8, rising into the chorus |
| **CHORUS 1** | 8 | chords, chord layer, bass, melody, drums | **Cut:** everything stops on beat 4 of m. 16 |
| **VERSE 2** | 4 | chords, bass, drums | **Fill:** a drum fill in m. 20 |
| **CHORUS 2** | 8 | chords, chord layer, bass, melody, drums | **Breakdown:** the drums and the pad drop out after m. 28 |
| **BRIDGE (OPTIONAL)** | – | not used in this skeleton | |
| **OUTRO** | 4 | chords, bass (first 2 measures) | **End:** the bass drops out after m. 30; the last chord rings on the I chord |

## COMPARE IT TO THE SONGS

Like Crazy and Blinding Lights, every section is 4 or 8 measures and the chorus is the fullest part. There is no pre-chorus: the build in m. 8 does that job. The verses are 4 measures because this is a skeleton; double them for a full song. The intro starts with one element and the outro strips back to one.

## WHAT A 5 SOUNDS LIKE

A listener can name every section by ear; the chorus still feels bigger with the melody muted (the pad and full drums carry it); every change has a transition you can name; the denser sections sit a little louder in the mix, and nothing clips.

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## CREDITS

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